

3.1 A Brief History Of Viruses

In this book we have studied viruses up close and personal, but do we know their entire story? Where did they all begin? What was the purpose behind the creation of the very first virus? What made viruses evolve to this level? For answers to these questions, we need to look at the history computer viruses.

Once Upon a Time...

The when and the where of the very first virus is a little fuzzy to history. The first program which showcased properties of what we now call viruses was called Elk Cloner, a program for the then popular Apple II; this was in 1981. Elk Cloner was quite the fairy-tale character, restricting itself to a fairy harmless rhyme that went like so:

*It will get on all your disks
It will infiltrate your chips
Yes it's Cloner!*

*It will stick to you like glue
It will modify RAM too
Send in the Cloner!*

Evidently, it was nothing more than a programmer's prank.

Then the world moved on to the mid-'80s; IBM had just created this little thing they called the PC, maybe you have heard of it. It was about the time when viruses started humming tunes of a more destructive nature. One of the first PC viruses discovered was known as the Brain virus, written by two brothers residing in Pakistan. The Brain was a boot-sector virus, infecting 360K floppy disks, but not hard drives. It would occupy unused space on a floppy such that the disk would become useless. Interestingly, Brain was also the first "stealth" virus, hiding itself from detection: if a computer user tried to view the disk sector, Brain would display the original, uninfected boot sector.